

Trump-Xi meeting puts rare earth truce to the test

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【要点】

- ・トランプ大統領と習近平主席の会談で、中国による希土類輸出制限が主要議題となり、米国の自動車・防衛・エネルギー産業に大きな影響を与える可能性がある。
- ・中国は2025年4月から希土類輸出を制限しており、11月10日に期限を迎える1年間の休戦協定が機能していない状況にある。
- ・トランプ政権は、希土類の適切な流通を求める一方で、自国の半導体輸出規制と希土類問題を交換条件にすることは拒否する姿勢を示している。
- ・AI大手のティム・クック氏やジェンセン・ファン氏など、希土類に依存する企業の幹部が会談に出席予定である。
- ・中国との2025年秋の休戦協定後、米国への希土類輸出は技術的には再開されたものの、過去の水準を大きく下回ったままである。

【メール原文】

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By Hannah Northey, James Bikales · Sep 23, 2026, 9:57 AM · [View in your browser](#)

A global tug-of-war over rare earths will be front and center Thursday when President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping meet in Washington, D.C. — and the outcome could have ripple effects in the U.S. auto, defense and energy sectors.

The summit comes as China has leveraged its dominance over production of rare earths as a trade weapon, restricting shipments of the materials that are crucial parts of the U.S. economy — including the rapidly growing AI industry and the auto sector. Despite a looming deadline when Beijing could ramp up its curbs on mineral exports, the Trump administration is signaling it does not intend to link the critical minerals discussions with the controls it has placed on exports to China, which has pushed the U.S. to ease restrictions on high-end semiconductors and other technology products.

Executives from AI tech giants reliant on rare earths will attend Thursday's state dinner with the two leaders at White House, including Apple executive chair Tim Cook, Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang, and Elon Musk, who heads up SpaceX and Tesla, according to the White House.

The Trump administration has chafed at restrictions on rare earths exports that Beijing has imposed since April 2025 and mostly continued despite agreeing to a one-year truce that ends Nov. 10. The president is poised to address that tension, a senior administration official told reporters Friday.

"China's performance in that respect has not been up to par of what we would expect, and that I'm sure will be a topic of discussion," the official said, though they added the administration is not willing to relax its own export controls for more certainty around rare earths.

"There's not going to be any exchange of export controls to get something that, in our view, we've already negotiated for, and that's the proper flow of rare earths into our and really the global economy," said the senior administration official.

Trump and Xi reached a truce in South Korea in the fall of 2025 to suspend Beijing's rare earth export restrictions for a year, but China soon imposed new barriers on exports to Japan and blacklisted U.S. rare earth producers including MP Materials, a company in which the U.S. Defense Department holds a 15% stake.

Gracelin Baskaran, director of the Critical Minerals Security Program at the Center for Strategic and International Studies think tank, said in a recent webinar that exports of rare earths to the U.S. that had collapsed in 2025 "technically resumed" after the truce was reached, but only modestly.

"Instead of returning to preexport restriction levels, exports remained well below historical averages for months," Baskaran said. "This slow recovery shows that while trade deals may be negotiated, Beijing retains a considerable amount of leverage and control over global export flows, determining who gets an export license and when."

When asked for comment, a spokesperson for the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of China said Beijing is committed to keeping global industrial and supply chains of critical minerals stable.

"China and the United States should jointly implement the important common understandings reached between the two presidents and maintain the steady growth momentum of China-U.S. economic and trade ties," said the spokesperson.

'Baseline minimum of what we should expect'

While the confrontation has cooled since the 2025 truce, rare earth exports remain subject to Beijing's strict licensing regime. At the same time, China has clamped down on deliveries to U.S. producers.

China has long been the dominant producer of the 17 types of rare earth elements, which must be separated and refined into oxides, metals or alloys. Once processed, the materials are used to make magnets for electronic components needed to manufacture everything from military equipment like munitions and fighter jets to EV motors and semiconductors.

Nick Myers, CEO of U.S. rare earths processor Phoenix Tailings, said most American manufacturers currently have little-to-no access to Chinese rare earths despite the trade truce. As Beijing has stepped up its artificial intelligence and robotics push, it wants to keep more of its rare earths production at home, Myers said.

"The Chinese have shipped several tons of material, but it's been very intermittent," he said. "The reality is, we're just going to get the leftovers from whatever they don't use."

Myers said the Trump administration's investments in the domestic rare earths sector are giving the U.S. an opportunity to "actually have legs in a Chinese negotiation as a country," but he acknowledged the coming years could be "painful" as the U.S. weans off Chinese supplies.

One person in the auto industry granted anonymity to speak freely about the sensitive trade situation said companies are hoping for stability and an extension of the November 2025 agreement, but there's no assurance the issue will come up during Trump's meeting with Xi.

If an agreement isn't reached, the U.S. industry — the auto sector and far beyond — could face production disruptions and less access to rare earth magnets, the person said. Automakers use rare earths to make permanent magnets for electric motors, sensors and equipment in both EVs and gas-powered vehicles.

Jonathan Czin, who served as China director on former President Joe Biden's National Security Council and as a senior China analyst for the CIA, said he expects the mineral truce to be extended.

"I think an extension of the gentlemen's agreement and continued access to rare earth is going to be the baseline minimum of what we should expect coming out of this meeting," said Czin, who is now at the Brookings Institution. "My understanding is that the real question right now is how long that truce is going to be extended for. Is it going to be six months?"

Under the trade détente, China has also suspended restrictions on the export of graphite anodes, a key battery material. If those were to go into effect, the impact on the U.S. economy would be devastating, according to Gene Berdichevsky, co-founder and CEO of Sila Nanotechnologies, which produces a silicon alternative to graphite anodes.

"My personal estimates are you could easily top 100,000 folks whose jobs could be impacted by that," he said, from auto manufacturers to the power sector, which is increasingly relying on massive grid-scale batteries to rein in rising electricity prices.

Berdichevsky's company was recently awarded a \$1.4 billion Pentagon loan for a major expansion project, but he acknowledged that it will be several years before the U.S. industry is mature enough to replace Chinese supplies.

"Diplomacy and derisking go hand in hand," Berdichevsky said. "The United States is making these big investments ... growing those alternatives, so that we can be in a position to prevent diplomatically any kind of hard decoupling that would materially damage, frankly, both economies."

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